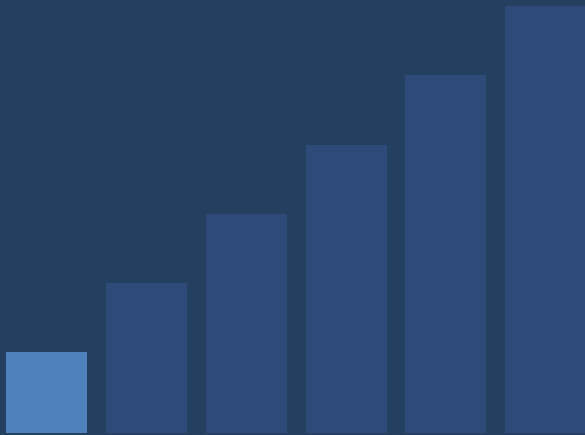




Brand Positioning is a Verb

Treating a brand position as a dynamic financial asset that needs to be supported and assessing the risk of underinvesting in it based on marketplace conditions.

Five things settled. One thing not.

Paul Syng argued in his June 28th essay that Ritson and Sharp agreed about much when they shared the stage in Cannes, but left the argument about Positioning unsettled.

1 Consistency is criminally undervalued

2 Mental availability matters most

3 Distinctive brand assets are non-negotiable

4 Sophisticated mass marketing beats niche thinking

5 Brand purpose is largely nonsense

NOT SETTLED

POSITIONING

The conversation around consistency didn't address brand positioning, a prerequisite for consistency. Positioning remains a point of disagreement between Sharp (Distinctiveness. Be recognizable) and Ritson (Distinctiveness plus relative differentiation).

Syng named the mechanism: positions are wired by costly, hard-to-copy decisions. This deck is intended to create a framework that marketers can use to:

1. Demonstrate how brand positioning is foundational to maintaining a consistent brand signal
2. Explore how the depth at which the brand position is embedded into the organization impacts integrated marketing's Job-to-be-Done
3. Create a framework to help marketers better defend marketing investments to the CFO

Brand positioning’s value has been identified and articulated through research that has nothing to do with marketing

Five fields, five findings — none from a practitioner selling a solution.

	Field and Study	Finding
George Miller <i>1956</i>	Psycholinguistics: applying information theory to human channel capacity. He was measuring people as communication channels.	Working memory holds ~7 things; the useful number is 3–5. You compete for one of a few slots, not for attention.
Eleanor Rosch <i>1970s</i>	Anthropological fieldwork: color naming among the Dani of New Guinea, testing whether language determines thought.	Categories have centers, not edges. Buyers reach for what sits closest to the center. Own the center, own the category.
Tversky & Kahneman <i>1970s</i>	Judgment under uncertainty: how people, including trained statisticians, misjudge probability. Reached economics later.	What comes to mind easily feels more likely, more right. Fluency does work the product can't.
Chamberlin & Robinson <i>1933</i>	Price theory: independently at Harvard and Cambridge, both fixing the failure of perfect competition to describe real markets.	Small differences create little monopolies in the buyer's mind and they get competed away unless something keeps rivals out.
Donald Hebb <i>1949</i>	Neuropsychology: working with Penfield on patients who'd had brain tissue removed, puzzled that large lesions didn't lower IQ.	Cells that fire together wire together; when the firing stops, the connection fades. The hinge for everything that follows.

Primary sources: Miller (1956), “The Magical Number Seven, Plus or Minus Two,” *Psychological Review*; Rosch Heider (1972), “Universals in Color Naming and Memory,” *Journal of Experimental Psychology*, and Rosch (1973), “Natural Categories,” *Cognitive Psychology*; Tversky & Kahneman (1974), “Judgment under Uncertainty: Heuristics and Biases,” *Science*; Chamberlin (1933), *The Theory of Monopolistic Competition*; Robinson (1933), *The Economics of Imperfect Competition*; Hebb (1949), *The Organization of Behavior*. Framing of these five fields follows Paul Syng, “Six Doors, One Room” (June 28, 2026).

Marketing research has measured the impact of Hebb's findings, but misunderstood it as a capacity problem and not a "wiring" one

Every message you add competes with the one you already paid to wire.

THE FINDING

More messages, less recall.

Marketing research supports Hebb's finding that adding messages to a campaign degrades recall of all of them.

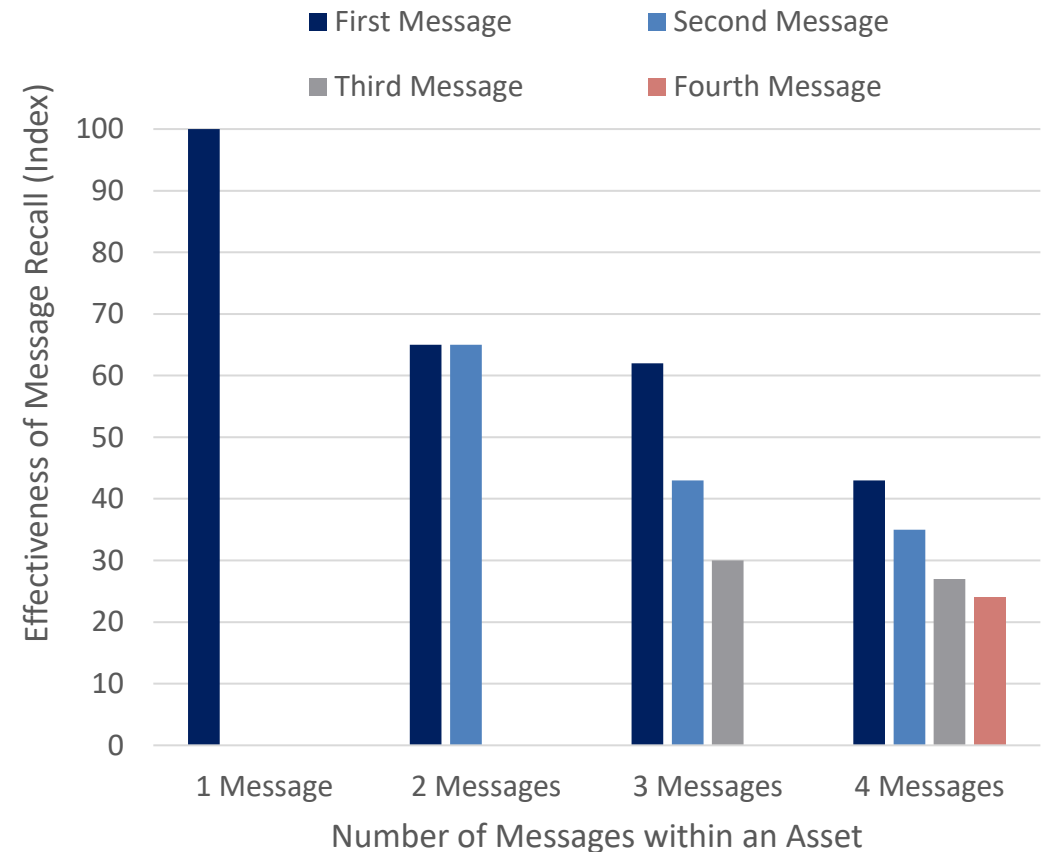
The field interpreted this result as a capacity problem, a storage limit, rather than a wiring one.

WHY THE DISTINCTION MATTERS

The brain doesn't average claims. It gets confused by them.

A capacity problem would require marketers to prioritize a message, the dilution problem requires marketers to ensure each message supports the brand association they are trying to reinforce; each new message weakens the existing ones.

Communicating more messages negatively impacts how each message is recalled by consumers



Brand positioning is built through repetition of a pattern in how the organization operates, external marketing efforts, or both

A brand position becomes a competitive advantage when it builds memory structures rivals can't easily or effectively copy. It is an asset that lives off the balance sheet.

Embedded in the organization

CONSISTENCY IN DECISIONS

- Load-bearing: decisions have significant downstream effects across divisions
- Investments are significant and would be expensive to copy due to the opportunity cost of dollars and resources
- Decisions to forgo opportunities that can drive incremental revenue because they would negatively impact the core position
- *Internal decisions influenced by a brand position are not always perceived by consumers or the marketplace at large*

Applied to an organization

CONSISTENCY IN EXPOSURE

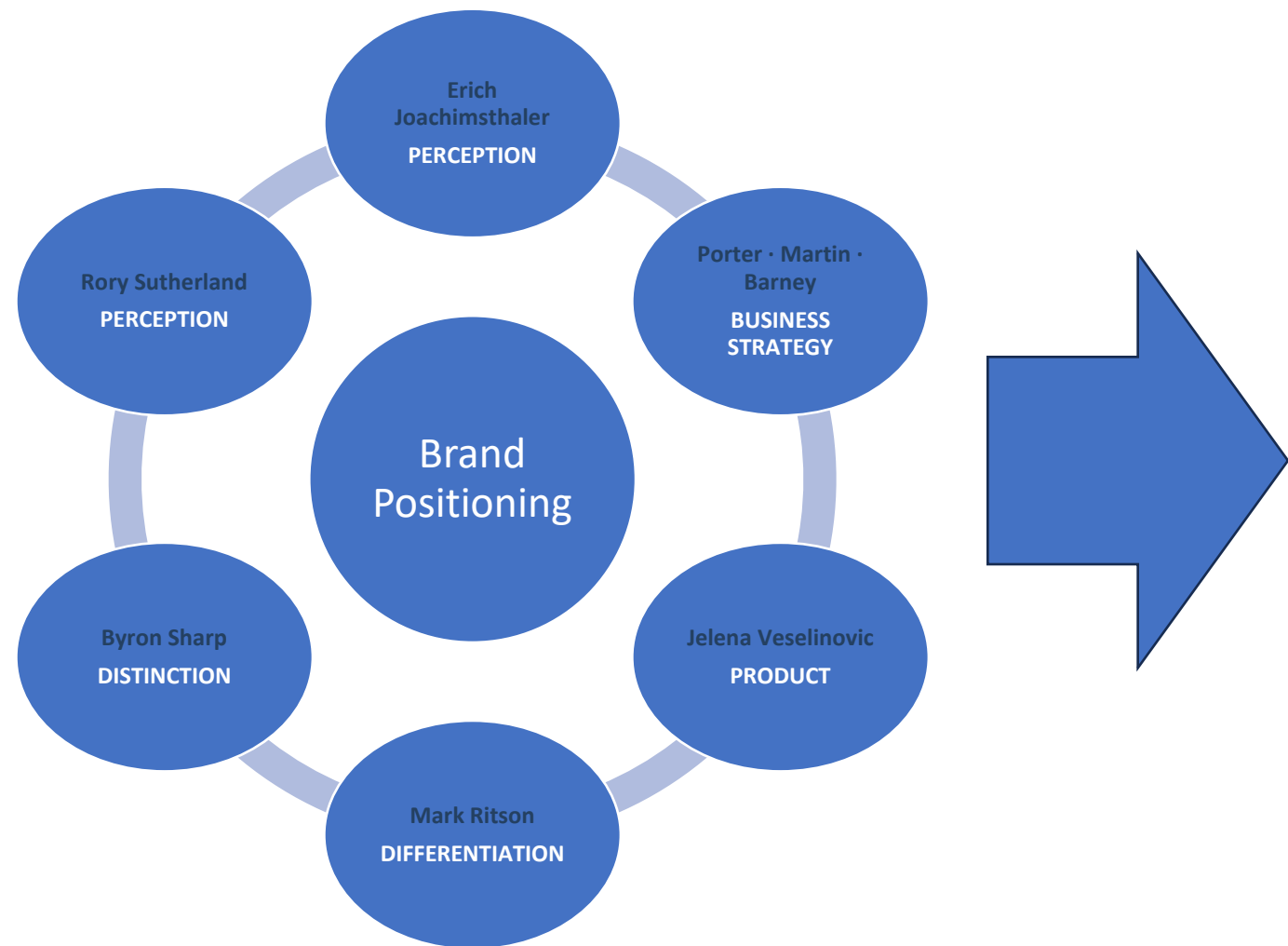
- Not load-bearing: decisions lack staying power and can be quickly reconsidered without disrupting the business
- Opportunity cost of dollars can be significant, but resource allocation carries less of an opportunity cost
- Brands can easily “test into” different positions to research consumer and category response
- *Are perceived by consumers and the marketplace by design, but can have little to no impact on how the business operates*

COST IS THE SEPARATOR: Three principles that show why embedded decisions defend a position better than leased tactics

1. Michael Spence (1973, Nobel 2001): a signal is only believed when it's expensive enough that a weaker player couldn't afford to fake it.
2. Thomas Schelling (1960): a commitment is credible precisely because it's costly to reverse.
3. Amotz Zahavi (1975): the peacock's tail is trusted because a weak bird couldn't afford to grow one.

Syng argued that practitioners were surrounding the topic of positioning, but their perspectives explored its merits at varying levels of depth

The more embedded brand positioning is within the organization, the more load-bearing it becomes and the more influence it has on internal and external marketing



PRACTITIONER	DEPTH OF POSITION	UNACCOUNTED FOR
Byron Sharp	DISTINCTION	Critical to build brand salience by building associations, no perspective on how to build new associations.
Rory Sutherland	PERCEPTION	Builds but doesn't defend positioning.
Mark Ritson	DIFFERENTIATION	States that meaning is worth having and defending, but not how to build it.
Jelena Veselinovic	PRODUCT	A reason, feature, or need state alone isn't a moat against competition.
Porter · Martin · Barney	BUSINESS STRATEGY	Not buyer-centric, focus is on how a firm operates.
Erich Joachimsthaler	DEMAND SPACE	Naming a new demand space invites competitors into the category.

The practitioners' arguments can be stacked on top of one another based on the depth at which the brand position is embedded into the organization

The more embedded brand positioning is within the organization, the more difficult it is for competitors to copy, for brands to change, and for consumers to perceive

PRACTITIONER	THE ARGUMENT	UNACCOUNTED FOR	DEPTH OF POSITION
Byron Sharp	The brand that comes to mind first sells the most, with a wall of data behind it. Difference is hard to find, easy to lose, rarely moves volume.	Critical to build brand salience by building associations, no perspective on how to build new associations.	DISTINCTION (not load-bearing)
Rory Sutherland	Price, imagery, experience can quickly change value perception.	Builds but doesn't defend.	PERCEPTION
Mark Ritson	Helps brand stand out on the shelf and can strengthen the value proposition to consumers (i.e. resulting in pricing power or consumer preference)	States that meaning is worth having and defending, but not how to build it.	DIFFERENTIATION
Jelena Veselinovic	A product needs to have a reason to exist before it can be successfully promoted and scaled.	A reason, feature, or need state alone isn't a moat against competition.	PRODUCT
Porter · Martin · Barney	Focus on the system, not a plan, claim, or tactic — a system is what a rival can't easily copy. Barney: advantage persists when the path to an execution can't be retraced and replicated cheaply.	Not buyer-centric, focus is on how a firm operates.	BUSINESS STRATEGY
Erich Joachimsthaler	Companies that let category penetration define their KPIs are measuring inside a market rather than choosing one. The demand space shapes the offering and confirms whether sufficient demand exists.	Naming a new demand space invites competitors into the category.	DEMAND SPACE (very load-bearing)

The depth at which a brand position sits within the organization informs integrated marketing's Job-to-be-Done

The phase and strength of a brand position are not static; they will change over time due to internal and external factors.

	Demand space	Business strategy	Product	Differentiation	Perception	Distinction
Example	OPENAI: ChatGPT became the generic word for a new category with a very high cost of entry. High cost of entry isn't a moat; well-funded rivals have arrived.	COSTCO: Caps its markup and makes its money on membership. A rival cannot copy the strategy without tearing up its income statement.	DAVID: The difference is an ingredient its competitors can't use. The proof is in the macros, not the message.	VOLVO: Decades of engineering decisions and crash data built the association with safety before the brand did.	PRIME: Celebrities made the product cool, but the brand was unable to sustain the position. Sales didn't sustain beyond the original hype cycle.	COCA-COLA: A century of ubiquity and cola wars.
AUDIENCE	Those who benefit from the new innovation or service	The sub-set of consumers that the business has identified	Those who benefit from the unique feature or want to be perceived as valuing the product difference	A sub-set within the category, defined against a rival	Multiple people within a category, segmented into sub-sets.	Everyone in the category, at every entry point
POSITIONING	Making the need clear and urgent	What the business will and won't do to win it	The feature as the solution to an existing problem.	The valuable difference from the rest of the category	Perceived value and borrowed association, varying by audience segment	Stronger recall than rivals across category entry points
COMMUNICATION	Make the need relevant to more people; grow the pool	Make internal decisions perceptible to buyers, and why that benefits them.	Make the benefit relevant, clear, and provable	Create preference against the competition	Right message to the right audience, at the right time	Win recall at purchase and in usage occasions

HIGH LOAD · HARD TO COPY · SLOW TO DECAY ← the deeper the position sits, the more of the business a rival has to rebuild to copy it → LOW LOAD · COPYABLE · FAST TO DECAY

Clarity around the Job-to-be-Done creates alignment between marketing's role and the results it should be expected to produce for the business

Marketing should always recruit new buyers, which assumes the demand space is real — a well-defended position is worth nothing if too few buyers value what it owns. Secondary KPIs come into play when marketing must manufacture a competitive advantage in consumers' minds.

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MARKETING SIGNAL	Aided brand awareness	Aided attribute association	Brand consideration	Brand preference	Unaided attribute association	Unaided brand awareness
BUSINESS OUTCOME	New buyers	New buyers	New buyers & Base sales vs. promo	New buyers & Repeat purchase	New buyers & Market share (by segment)	New buyers & Product velocity

Data inputs that inform the risk associated with cutting marketing spend

Advertising can't save every brand, but sales typically erode when a brand stops advertising — and larger brands, likely carrying more 'wires,' lose momentum more slowly.

1 WIRE DEPENDENCE:

How much of your price leans on perception rather than the product?

- Does branding impact brand preference (taste test)
- Does marketing impact price sensitivity (% of volume on promotion vs. base) or discourage switching when competitors run promotions
- Repeat rate of buyers acquired with zero media exposure

2 DECAY RATE:

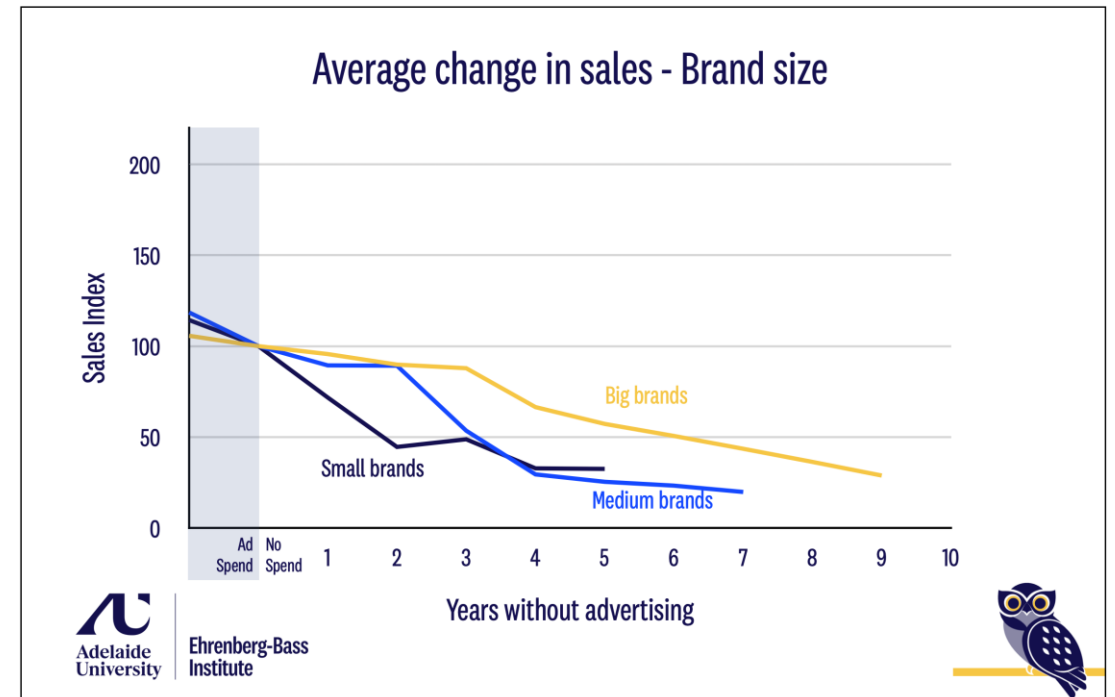
How fast does the wire fade once you stop firing it?

- Do purchase cycles grow longer when the brand is dark, and how does that compare to the category overall?
- How quickly does the brand lose unaided awareness and brand consideration gained from media exposure?

3 REPLACEMENT SPEED:

How fast can a funded rival occupy your space?

- What would be your competitors' expected excess share-of-voice (eSOV) if investment is reduced?
- How much does the category typically invest in marketing relative to their revenue, and are competitors in position to invest more if they see you've cut spending?
- How many competitors can credibly carry brand positioning, eroding yours



Illustrative framework — inputs shown are the factors to assess, not a completed analysis.

Chart: Ehrenberg-Bass Institute, "What happens when brands stop advertising?" (Gelzinis, Kennedy, Beal, Hartnett & Sharp), Chart 2 — 57 cases of brands cutting all mass media spend, one Australian consumer-goods category, 20+ years. Single-category evidence; the Institute notes generalisability is still being tested.

Budget cuts are free to finance because they consider a position to be static; brand positioning in a category is dynamic as brands gain/lose momentum

Marketing's impact does not depreciate on a predictable schedule like other capital assets; it is determined by known and unknown marketplace factors



Assessing the long-term risk of a marketing cut based on brand positioning

Risk $\approx$ WIRE DEPENDENCE (how often the proof would have fired) $\times$ DECAY RATE (whether anything fires without media) $\times$ REPLACEMENT SPEED (how fast a rival can take the slot)

The Risk	The cut is:	The implications:
VERY HIGH RISK	an EXIT decision.	You are assuming that competitors won't attempt to steal your share of sales by moving into your brand position. You are effectively deciding to exit a category. Impact measured in weeks
HIGH RISK	a CAPITAL decision (asymmetric).	You are assuming rivals can't take your position, but winning it back costs more than the original build. The cut is cheap; the reversal is not. Impact measured in quarters, recovery in years.
LOW RISK	a CAPITAL decision (recoverable).	You are assuming that competitors won't aggressively move into your brand position based on past performance The saving is real AND so is the depreciation. Monitor category activity closely to protect against vulnerabilities. Impact measured in quarters.
VERY LOW RISK	a COST decision.	The market rewards brands that own a unique space or have a unique proposition. The capability of the product is the marketing. The saving is close to real. Impact measured in years.

Brand positions become competitive advantages when they are well defended and cannot be easily (or cheaply) copied by rivals.

1

Being consistent is a product of having a strong brand position. This brand position can be deeply embedded into the organization (and potentially hard to perceive from the outside) or a product of consistent external exposures (through marketing investment).

2

The role of integrated marketing can change based on how deeply embedded into an organization a brand's position is. The more deeply embedded into an organization, the easier it is for integrated marketing to defend it and the harder it is for the organization to change it.

3

How deeply embedded a brand's position in the marketplace is informs the level of risk to the business if it is not sufficiently supported. A brand position is not a static state, so the level of risk will change over time as marketplace factors evolve.